turban and a bejewelled sash over his shoulder. His overcoat was ornamented with precious stones, and he wore the Koh-i-Nur on his right forearm, and the Fakhraj ruby on his left. His Highness Timur Shah also mounted another encrusted brooch on his horse's forehead. Because he was a man of short stature, a bejewelled stepstool was also made for him to mount his horse.'[16] Though Timur Shah lost the Persian territories of his father's empire, he fought hard to preserve the Afghan core: in 1778–9, he recovered the rebellious Punjabi city of Multan, his father's birthplace, returning with the heads of several thousand Sikh rebels laden on camels. The heads were then put on display as trophies.[17]

Timur left twenty-four sons, and the succession struggle that followed his death – with all the competing claimants energetically capturing, murdering and maiming each other – began the process of undermining the authority of the Durrani monarchy; under Timur Shah's eventual successor, Shah Zaman, the Empire disintegrated. In 1797, Shah Zaman, like his father and grandfather before him, decided to revive his fortunes and fill his treasuries by ordering a full-scale invasion of Hindustan – the time-honoured Afghan solution to cash crises. Encouraged by an invitation from Tipu Sultan, he descended the switchbacks of the Khyber Pass and moved into the old monsoon-weathered walls of the Mughal fort of Lahore to plan his raid on the rich plains of north India. By 1797, however, India was increasingly coming under the sway of a frighteningly alien intrusion into the region: the East India Company. Under its most aggressive Governor General, Lord Wellesley, the elder brother of the future Duke of Wellington, the Company was expanding rapidly out from its coastal factories to conquer much of the interior; Wellesley's Indian campaigns would ultimately annex more territory than all of Napoleon's conquests in Europe. India was no longer the source of easy plunder for the Afghans that it once was, and Wellesley was an especially cunning adversary.

He decided to thwart Shah Zaman, not through direct force of arms, but through diplomatic stratagem. In 1798, he sent a diplomatic mission to Persia, offering arms and training, and encouraged the Persians to attack Shah Zaman's undefended rear. Shah Zaman was forced to retreat in 1799, and in the process left Lahore under the governorship of a capable and ambitious young Sikh. Rajah Ranjit Singh had helped Shah Zaman save some cannon lost in the mud of the River Jhelum during the chaos of the Afghan retreat, and by charming the Shah, and impressing him with his